

EC 91: Topics in the Economics of Education

Tufts University

Fall 2026

Syllabus subject to revision; the latest version, with links, is at <https://canvas.tufts.edu/courses/76190>

Instructor: Monica Agarwal

Email: Monica.Agarwal@tufts.edu

Office: 97 Talbot Avenue, Room 101

Office hours: Monday 11:00 a.m.–12:30 p.m. (in person, or on Zoom by request)

Class time: MW 9:00–10:15 a.m.

Classroom: Joyce Cummings Center, Room 074

Course Overview

This course applies economic tools and methods to study one of society's most significant investments: education. Why do people invest in schooling, and how large is the return to that investment? Does education raise productivity, or does it primarily signal ability that workers already possess? Does additional spending, such as on smaller classes, teacher quality, or new technology, improve student achievement? What are the effects of school choice, test-based accountability, and teacher compensation policy? We address these questions through the models and empirical methods of economics, with an emphasis on distinguishing causation from correlation. The focus is on primary and secondary education in the United States.

The prerequisite for this course is EC 5 or EC 8.

Textbook

The required text is *Economics of Education* (2018), by Michael Lovenheim and Sarah Turner. It is the only textbook on the economics of education at the undergraduate level. You may rent the book or purchase it in digital or paperback form from the Tufts University Bookstore. A few copies will also be placed as course reserves at the Tisch Library.

Course Policies and Expectations

1. Communication

I will regularly post announcements about class, problem sets, and readings on Canvas, and you are responsible for reading them. You may reach me by email, and you are welcome to meet with me during my office hours if you have questions about the course or the assignments.

2. Lecture slides

Students will have access to lecture slides – these will be posted on canvas after lecture.

3. Missed exams and in-class work

There will be no make-ups for missed exams. A student who misses an exam because of illness or because of an emergency will have the weight of that exam shifted to the other course elements. If this happens, please tell me as soon as you can.

There will also be no make-ups if you miss class on a day when we do in-class open-notes problems. I will drop the two lowest in-class grades to cover any classes you need to miss, whether because of illness or other circumstances.

4. Academic integrity

General: Tufts holds its students strictly accountable for adherence to academic integrity. It is critical that you understand the requirements of ethical behavior and academic work as described in Tufts' Academic Integrity handbook. If you ever have a question about the expectations concerning a particular assignment or project in this course, please ask me for clarification. I encourage you to work together and to talk to each other about the readings and the assignments, but the final work that you turn in must be your own. The Faculty of the School of Arts and Sciences are required to report suspected cases of academic integrity violations to the Dean of Student Affairs Office. If I have reason to suspect that you have cheated or plagiarized in this class, I must report the situation to the dean. For more information, see Tufts' Academic Integrity policy

<https://students.tufts.edu/community-standards/academic-integrity/academic-integrity-overview>

Exams: To avoid any appearance of cheating, you will be required to put away all written and electronic material before the start of any exam, with the exception of department issued calculators (these are in the main office and can be picked up before the exam). Please do not engage in behavior that gives the appearance of cheating, such as passing a note to a friend, whispering to another student while the exam is in progress, or looking in the direction of another student's work. If you must bring an electronic device to an exam room, please do not touch or use it during the exam. Please turn off your cell phone and put it out of reach before the exam begins.

5. Generative AI

Generative AI tools are now widely available, however, there is causal evidence that students who lean heavily on AI do well on take-home work and noticeably worse on exams – we'll talk about this on the first day of class. As these tools get better, the ability to reason through an unfamiliar problem on your own becomes more valuable, not less.

You may not submit text generated by an AI system — ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, or any other — as your own work. In particular, do not paste an assignment into an AI tool and submit what it returns, in whole or in part. Submitting answers you did not produce and do not understand is academic dishonesty and will be treated as academic misconduct.

You may use AI as part of your preparation: It can help to generate ideas and correct grammar. It can be used to support your work, but not to do your work for you. Be skeptical of what AI

produces. The work you hand in must be written by you. If you use AI on an assignment, add a brief note at the end saying what you used it for; failure to disclose is a violation of academic integrity. I reserve the right to submit any work you hand in to an AI checker.

6. Regrade requests and grades on Canvas

A grader may be helping me grade exams and/or problem sets. If you believe a question has been graded incorrectly, please email me within one week of the date the graded work was returned, specifying which question part or parts you would like regraded and why. I reserve the right to change grades up or down, based on those question parts or on any other part of the assignment.

Please review your grades on Canvas throughout the semester. Very rarely, an assignment is misplaced or a grade is entered in error. If, a week after an assignment was due, you do not see a grade on Canvas, check with me to make sure it was not lost. If a grade in Canvas does not match what was on the work returned to you, let me know right away. With the exception of issues regarding the second exam, all such issues must be brought to my attention by the last day of class (December 9), so that we have time to resolve them before grades are due.

7. Devices in class

Laptops and tablets may be used in class for taking notes only. I reserve the right to restrict their use more generally. Please do not use phones in class.

Grading and Late Submission Policy

Component	Weight
Class participation	5%
In-class open-notes problems	20%
Problem sets	15%
First in-class exam (closed book)	30%
Second in-class exam (closed book)	30%

1. Participation (5%)

Attending class and active participation will help your participation grade.

2. In-class open-notes problems (20%)

In several weeks, students will work through problems in class. It will not be possible to announce these dates in advance, so plan to attend all classes. You may work with a neighbor and consult your class notes, but you must submit your own work at the end of class. **Solutions will be posted after class, so late submissions cannot be accepted. I will drop your lowest two in-class grades**, which should cover any classes you need to miss because of illness or other circumstances. If you miss

more than two, each additional missed problem will count as a zero. After the two drops, every remaining in-class problem counts equally toward this component of your grade.

3. Problem sets (15%)

Five problem sets will be posted on Canvas, and you will have at least seven days to complete each one. I will announce the posting date and the corresponding due date at least one week in advance. **I will drop your lowest problem set grade**, which should cover any week you need to miss because of illness or other circumstances. After the drop, every remaining problem set counts equally toward this component of your grade.

Problem sets are due at 5:00 p.m. on the due date. You may either upload your work to Canvas or hand in a paper copy in class. If you have trouble uploading to Canvas, please email me a copy before the deadline.

If you anticipate needing an extension, please let me know at least 48 hours before the due date — for example, if a problem set is due at 5:00 p.m. on Wednesday, request the extension by 5:00 p.m. on Monday. All extension requests can be made on Canvas. Excused extensions are allowed for up to 72 hours past the original deadline: work submitted within that window will receive full credit, and work submitted after it will receive no credit. Unexcused late work will receive 75% credit if it is submitted within 24 hours of the deadline, and no credit thereafter.

4. In-class exams ($2 \times 30\% = 60\%$)

There will be two in-class exams. These will be closed book exams. The second exam is non-cumulative, meaning that it covers only the topics that were not part of the first exam.

Key Dates

- ☐ Wednesday, October 21: wrap-up and review for the first exam
- ☐ Monday, October 26: first exam (in class, 9:00–10:15 a.m.)
- ☐ Wednesday, December 9: wrap-up and review for the second exam
- ☐ Monday, December 14: second exam (in class, 9:00–10:15 a.m.)

Course Outline

The course is organized into modules. The table below summarizes the sequence of topics and the assigned reading for each. Exact due dates for Problem sets will be announced in class and posted on Canvas. This schedule is preliminary and subject to change.

Module / Topic	Reading	Assignments
Module 1. Foundations		
Why economists study education policy	Chapter 1	
The structure and history of U.S. education markets	Chapter 2	

Module / Topic	Reading	Assignments
Module 2. Investment in education and returns to education		Problem Sets 1–3
The human capital model	Chapter 4	
The signaling model	Chapter 5	
Correlation vs Causation	Parts of Chapter 3 & Slides	
The returns to education investment	Chapter 6	
Wrap up and Review: Wednesday, October 21 (in class)		
Exam 1: Monday, October 26 (in class)		
Module 3. Elementary and secondary education policy		Problem Set 4 & 5
The education production function	Chapter 7	
The financing of local public schools	Chapter 8	
School resources and student outcomes	Chapter 9	
School choice	Chapter 10	
Test-based accountability	Chapter 11	
Teacher labor markets	Chapter 12	
Module 4. Higher education (time permitting)		
Higher education markets, paying for college, and college life	Chapters 13–15	
Wrap up and Review: Wednesday, December 9 (in class)		
Exam 2: Monday, December 14 (in class)		

Student Resources

Accommodations for students with disabilities

Tufts University values the diversity of our students, staff, and faculty and recognizes the important contribution each student makes to our unique community. Tufts is committed to providing equal access and support to all qualified students through the provision of reasonable accommodations so that each student may fully participate in the Tufts experience. If you have a disability that requires reasonable accommodations, please contact the StAAR Center (formerly Student Accessibility Services) at StaarCenter@tufts.edu or 617-627-4539 to make an appointment with an accessibility representative to determine appropriate accommodations. Please be aware that accommodations cannot be enacted retroactively, making timeliness a critical aspect for their provision.

I encourage anyone who needs accommodation during exams to make arrangements through the StAAR Center. Their spaces fill up, so please contact them early in the semester.

Academic support at the StAAR Center

The StAAR Center (formerly the Academic Resource Center and Student Accessibility Services) offers a variety of resources to all students, both undergraduate and graduate, in the Schools of Arts and Sciences, Engineering, the SMFA, and Fletcher; services are free to all enrolled students. Students may make an appointment to work on any writing-related project or assignment, attend subject tutoring in a variety of disciplines, or meet with an academic coach to hone fundamental academic skills such as time management or overcoming procrastination. Students can make an appointment for any of these services by visiting the StAAR Center website (go.tufts.edu/StAARCenter).

Mental health support

As a student, there may be times when personal stressors or emotional difficulties interfere with your academic performance or well-being. The Dean of Student Affairs Office offers support and care to undergraduate and graduate students who are experiencing difficulties, and can also aid faculty in their work with students. The Counseling and Mental Health Service (CMHS) provides confidential consultation, brief counseling, and urgent care at no cost for all Tufts undergraduates, as well as for graduate students who have paid the student health fee. To make an appointment, call 617-627-3360. Please visit the CMHS website (go.tufts.edu/Counseling) to learn more about their services and resources.

Religious accommodations

Tufts University faculty, staff, and administration highly value and acknowledge the religious diversity of its student body. Students seeking religious accommodations related to their holy days are encouraged to collaborate with faculty to make arrangements during the first week of each semester. The religious holy days calendar, including the holy days policy from the Faculty Handbook, is available <https://students.tufts.edu/registrar/courses-and-calendars/academic-calendar#paragraph-22371> . Students seeking additional support may refer to the University Religious Accommodations Policy. The University Chaplaincy is also available to respond to questions on religious observances.

Diversity and inclusion

This course is designed with the goal of ensuring that students from all backgrounds and perspectives are well served, that students' learning needs are addressed both in and out of class, and that the diversity students bring to this class is viewed as a resource, a strength, and a benefit. We will aim to present materials and activities that are respectful of diversity in gender, sexuality, disability, age, socioeconomic status, ethnicity, race, and culture. Please do not hesitate to let me know how the course could be made more effective for you along any of these dimensions. In addition, if any of our class meetings conflict with your religious observances, please let me know so that we can make appropriate arrangements.